

Cited and adapted from: <https://pressbooks.pub/speakingconfidently/chapter/developing-arguments/>

And <https://www.numberanalytics.com/blog/mastering-warrant-rhetoric-composition>

And <https://spellapp.com/resources/how-to-write-a-warrant-in-an-essay>

Part III Warrant

The third component of any argument is the warrants, which are implicit or explicit assumptions that justify the inference from evidence to claim. They provide the underlying reasoning or principle that makes the argument valid and sound.

Types of Warrants: Motivational, Authoritative, and Substantive

There are three primary types of warrants: motivational, authoritative, and substantive.

Motivational Warrants: These warrants appeal to the audience's emotions, values, and motivations. They create an emotional connection between the claim and the evidence, making the argument more relatable and persuasive. For example, a motivational warrant might be used in a charity advertisement to appeal to the audience's sense of empathy and compassion.

Authoritative Warrants: These warrants rely on the credibility and authority of the source or expert. They establish trust and confidence in the argument by citing reputable sources or experts in the field. For instance, an authoritative warrant might be used in a research paper to support a claim with data from a credible study.

Substantive Warrants: These warrants are based on the underlying logic and reasoning of the argument. They provide a clear and logical connection between the claim and the evidence, making the argument more convincing and persuasive. For example, a substantive warrant might be used in a mathematical proof to establish the validity of a theorem.

Significance of Warrants

Warrants often answers the question, “what does this mean?” They are an important component of a complete argument because they:

- Highlight the significance of the evidence;
- Detail how the evidence supports the claims;
- Outline the relevance of the claim and evidence to the audience.

For example, consider the claim that “communication studies provide necessary skills to land you a job.” To support that claim, you might locate a statistic and argue that, “The New York Times had a recent article stating that 80% of jobs want good critical thinking and interpersonal skills.” It’s unclear, however, how a communication studies major would prepare someone to fulfill those needs. To complete the argument, you could include a warrant that explains, “communication studies classes facilitate interpersonal skills and work to embed critical thinking activities throughout the curriculum.” You are connecting the job skills (critical thinking) from the evidence to the discipline (communication studies) from your claim.

Despite their importance, warrants are often excluded from arguments. As speechwriters and researchers, we spend lots of time with our information and evidence, and we take for granted what we know. If you are familiar with communication studies, the connection between the New York Times statistic referenced above and the assertion that communication studies provides necessary job skills may seem obvious. For an unfamiliar audience, the warrant provides more explanation and legitimacy to the evidence.

Some warrants are indeed inferred, meaning that we often recognize the underlying warrant without it being explicitly stated. For example, I might say, “The baking time for my cookies was

too hot. The cookies burned.” In this statement, I’m claiming that the temperature is too hot and using burnt cookies as the evidence. We could reasonably infer the warrant, i.e. “burnt cookies are a sign that they were in the oven for too long.”

Inferred warrants are common in everyday arguments and conversations; however having a clear warrant will increase the clarity of your argument. If you decide that no explicit warrant is needed, it’s still necessary to ask, “what does this argument mean for my thesis? What does it mean for my audience?” Your goal is to retain as many audience members as possible, and warrants allow you to think critically about the information that you’re presenting to that audience.

Writing Warrants: A Step-by-Step Guide

Now that you understand what warrants are and why they matter, let's dive into writing them. Crafting a good warrant involves a few key steps that help ensure your argument is solid and convincing.

1. Clearly Define Your Claim and Evidence

Before writing a warrant, ensure your thesis is clear and specific. Vague or broad theses make it difficult to create strong warrants. Once your thesis is set, gather specific evidence that directly supports it.

2. Identify the Underlying Assumption

Reflect on the assumption that links your evidence to your thesis. This requires critical thinking and a deep understanding of your topic. Ask yourself, What must be true for this evidence to support my thesis?

3. Write the Warrant

With your assumption in mind, write the warrant in a clear and concise manner. Make sure it explicitly connects your evidence to your thesis. A well-crafted warrant leaves no doubt about the relationship between your evidence and the main argument. Here are some tips for you to follow when writing warrants:

- Avoid exaggerating your evidence, and make sure your warrant honors what the evidence is capable of supporting;
- Center your thesis statement. Remember that your thesis statement, as your main argument, should be the primary focus when you’re explaining and warranting your evidence.
- A good warrant should be crafted with your content and context in mind. As you work on warrants, ask, “why is this claim/evidence important here? For this argument? Now? For this audience?”
- Say it with us: ethos, pathos, and logos! Warrants can help clarify the goal of your argument. What appeal are you using? Can the warrant amplify that appeal?
- Avoid fallacies: fallacies are errors in reasoning that can weaken the argument. Common fallacies include ad hominem attacks, straw man arguments, and false dilemmas.

Combining the three components we’ve learned together, we can develop an argument as follows:

Claim: The Iowa Wildcats will win the championship.

Evidence: In 2019, the National Sporting Association found that the Wildcats had the most consistent and well-rounded coaching staff. Referees of the game agreed, and also praised the players' ability for high scoring.

Warrant: Good coaching and high scoring are probable indicators of past champions and, given this year's findings, the Wildcats are on mark to win it all.

Final Thoughts

Mastering the art of warrant in rhetoric is crucial for crafting compelling arguments that resonate with the audience. By understanding the different types of warrants and how to craft effective warrants, you can create persuasive arguments that convince and engage your audience. Whether you're writing a research paper, crafting an editorial, or delivering a speech, warrants play a critical role in establishing the validity and credibility of your argument.

Vocabulary

序号	单词	中文释义	地道例句
1	implicit	含蓄的；暗示的	The contract contains an implicit clause regarding data protection.
2	explicit	明确的；直言的	The manager made explicit his expectations for the team's performance.
3	justification	正当理由；辩护	There is no moral justification for the use of excessive force.
4	inference	推论；推断	Her inference from the data was supported by further research.
5	valid	有效的；有根据的	The study's conclusions are valid only if the sample is representative.
6	motivational	激励性的；动机的	The speaker delivered a motivational talk to inspire young entrepreneurs.
7	authoritative	权威的；官方的	This book is an authoritative guide to international law.
8	substantive	实质的；本质的	The two sides reached a substantive agreement on trade tariffs.
9	empathy	共情；同理心	Leaders with empathy can better understand their employees' needs.
10	compassion	同情；怜悯	The charity's work is driven by compassion for the homeless.
11	reputable	声誉好的；受尊敬的	She found a job at a reputable engineering firm in the city.
12	theorem	定理；命题	The mathematician spent years proving the complex theorem.
13	facilitate	促进；使便利	Technology can facilitate communication between remote teams.
14	embed	嵌入；植入	The app embeds safety features to protect user privacy.
15	assertion	断言；主张	The politician's assertion was met with skepticism by the public.
16	legitimacy	合法性；合理性	The new government's legitimacy was questioned by opposition parties.

序号	单词	中文释义	地道例句
17	inferred	推断出的；推论的	The researchers inferred a link between diet and heart disease.
18	retain	保留；保持	The company aims to retain top talent through competitive salaries.
19	critical	批判性的；关键的	Effective time management is critical to project success.
20	convincing	有说服力的；令人信服的	The lawyer presented a convincing case to the jury.
21	concise	简洁的；简明的	The executive summary should be concise and to the point.
22	exaggerate	夸大；夸张	Some media outlets tend to exaggerate the impact of new technologies.
23	context	语境；背景	To understand the poem, one must consider its historical context.
24	amplify	增强；放大	Social media can amplify both positive and negative messages.
25	fallacies	谬误；谬论	The article exposes common fallacies in popular health advice.
26	ad hominem	人身攻击的	The debate descended into ad hominem attacks rather than substantive discussion.
27	straw man	稻草人谬误；歪曲论点	The politician set up a straw man argument to avoid addressing the real issue.
28	dilemma	困境；两难抉择	Many families face the dilemma of choosing between work and childcare.
29	compelling	引人入胜的；有说服力的	The documentary presents a compelling case for climate action.
30	resonate	引起共鸣；产生反响	Her speech on social justice resonated with audiences across the country.

Exercise

I Fill in the blanks using the most appropriate words from the vocabulary.

Context	Implicit	dilemma	facilitate	reputable	concise
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1. The agreement includes an _____ understanding that both parties will cooperate on future projects.
2. When writing academic papers, it's essential to cite _____ sources to strengthen your points.
3. Using visual aids can _____ the audience's understanding of complex arguments.
4. A good warrant should be _____ yet comprehensive enough to link evidence and claim.
5. To interpret the author's argument correctly, we must consider the cultural _____ of the text.

II Circle the most suitable choice to replace the underlined word.

1. The manager made explicit his requirements for the upcoming project.
A. clear B. hidden C. complex D. flexible
2. The politician's assertion that the policy will reduce unemployment was met with public skepticism.
A. compassion B. proposition C. context D. justification
3. The researcher presented a compelling analysis of the experiment results.
A. boring B. persuasive C. confusing D. simple
4. The discovery has great significance for the development of medical technology.
A. importance B. similarity C. difference D. weakness
5. The conclusion was inferred from the data collected over three months.
A. ignored B. proven C. deduced D. forgotten

III Translate the following sentences into Chinese/ English.

1. 优质课程会将批判性思维训练嵌入整个教学过程中。(embed)
2. 一个有说服力的论证需以实质依据为基础，避免空洞的表述。(substantive)
3. 这个新政策的合理性必须通过公开讨论来确立。(legitimacy)
4. 清晰的论证结构有助于在演讲中保留更多听众。(retain)
5. 恰当的例子能增强论点的说服力，引发听众共鸣。(amplify)